

Anarchist Political School

Anarchism and the trade unions



Solidarity, June 30, 1917. The Hand That Will Rule the World—One Big Union.

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Modules in this series:

MODULE 1: Class, capitalism and the state

MODULE 2: Reform or revolution?

MODULE 3: Anarchism and organisation

MODULE 4: Anarchism and the trade unions

MODULE 5: Fighting oppressions of gender and sexuality

MODULE 6: Racism, colonisation and indigenous struggle

MODULE 7: The environmental crisis

MODULE 8: Internationalism, imperialism and national liberation

MODULE 9: The Russian revolution

MODULE 10: The Spanish revolution

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Trade Unions

Capitalism brings workers together in large workplaces and into large towns and cities, and it makes us cooperate every day at work. From hospitals to fast food outlets, production is broken down into processes involving tens, hundreds, or even thousands of different workers who each have to do their bit so that production can continue.

Individually, workers have very little power in the process of production. We find ourselves forced to do jobs that are low paid, dangerous, or demeaning. Workers who demand changes or refuse to do their job are easily sacked and replaced. But ever since capitalism first brought large numbers of workers together, workers have realised that collectively they have great power. A boss can sack and replace one worker, but they can rarely sack and replace all the workers. One worker refusing to do their job changes little, but all workers refusing to do their job can bring the economic system to its knees.

Trade unions (or just unions) are the organisations workers built in order to assert their class interests against those of the bosses. Historically, workers have organised in trade unions in order to fight for the 8 hour day, the weekend, higher wages, greater workplace safety, universal healthcare and a host of other

economic demands resisted by capitalists. Unions have also taken part in political campaigns of broader interest to the working class, fighting for civil rights, equal pay for men and women and against violent and repressive government policies.

Trade unions are organised 'at the point of production', that is they are based in the workplace. Trade unions only have power in a workplace or industry when most of the workers in that workplace or industry are members of that trade union. They are strongest when all workers are united, irrespective of race, gender, sexuality or other divisions.

Because the trade unions are based at the point of production, they can wield the strongest weapon that workers have under capitalism: the withdrawal of their labour. They allow workers to fight the bosses and the governments that serve them. They also give workers an idea of their potential power and ability to run their own lives.

Militant and democratic trade unions are therefore one of the most powerful organs of class struggle and building them is a task of utmost importance for anarchist communists.

Discuss

What is special about the withdrawal of labour? How is it different from other courses of action available to workers to express their dissatisfaction?

The Bureaucracy & The State

Workers won the right to form and belong to unions through struggle. However, over the course of the past 150 years, most of the world's unions have been integrated within the legal and political frameworks of the capitalist state.

In Australia, the draconian legislative framework that regulates the unions today has essentially made all effective union action illegal. The right to strike has been stripped so far back and burdened with so many conditions that it is now close to impossible to exercise it legally and effectively at the same time.

The actions of most unions within Australia are dominated by a bureaucracy of full time and often unelected officials. Many officials enter trade unions straight out of university and have often never worked in the industry they represent. Many see climbing the ranks of a union as a stepping stone to leverage a future career in the Australian Labor Party (ALP).

The central task of the bureaucracy is to broker deals between workers and employers. However, due to a lack of solid democratic structures within the unions, the officials are not directly responsible to the membership once in office. But the bureaucracy in the unions can never become totally unresponsive to the demands of the membership.¹ This would result in the end of their power, privileges and careers, as members would leave the unions en masse.

The bureaucracy has economic interests that clash with those of regular trade union members (the rank-and-file). Workers join unions in order to fight for improved pay, conditions and safety at work, but the officials join unions to pursue careers within them. The officials are therefore reliant upon the continuation of the bureaucracy, in order to keep their careers moving along smoothly. They are quick to suppress any kind of worker-led action that would threaten their position, prefer conciliation to class warfare and will argue for compromise in negotiations at the earliest possible juncture.

The union officials behave this way not because individual officials are sell-outs, but because of their power and position within the unions. The repressive industrial relations regime that regulates the unions

¹This doesn't apply in circumstances of compulsory membership, or where employers "encourage" it. The SDA is an example in Australia. Yellow unions are well known overseas.

compels the officials to act as a police force over their members.

Discuss

Should workers ever organise to try to replace conservative union bureaucrats with officials who will fight on the members' behalf?

The Labor Party

The peak body of the Australian trade union movement, the ACTU, gathers together the trade union officials from almost all unions in Australia. The ACTU acts as a means for the bureaucracy to pool together their resources to influence the Labor Party. Most unions are also directly affiliated with the ALP, bypassing the ACTU.

But the ACTU, and the unions in general, are not just mere lobby groups that seek to pressure the ALP from the outside. Rather, trade union officials are involved within the ALP at every level of its operation. Leading trade union officials also move seamlessly between trade union positions and political positions in the ALP. So ultimately, the ALP is the party of the trade union bureaucracy.

The bureaucratisation of the unions has seriously dampened the fighting spirit of the working class. It has

transformed most unions into 'election machines'
dedicated to ensuring the re-election of the Labor Party.

Discuss

Is 'a vote for Labor' a 'vote for the unions'?

The Accord

To attempt to resolve a stagflation crisis in the late 1970s – a time of both high unemployment and low growth – the Liberal government of Malcolm Fraser attempted to impose a wage freeze on workers. The unions resisted with strikes, and the freeze was never successfully implemented.

But capital still needed a way to restore the crisis. Bob Hawke's ALP, which came into power in 1983, would provide the solution. Upon election, the ALP signed the Accord with the ACTU. The Accord narrowly confined what unions could (legally) fight for and in particular, it set an upper bound on union wage claims. The right to strike was restricted accordingly. In exchange, the 'social wage' (i.e. the benefits Australian workers received from the state, like Medicare and superannuation) was expanded.

This agreement was a long term disaster for Australian unions. From 1983, the Accord compelled the union

bureaucracy to act as a police force over the rank-and-file. Any strikes or unions that failed to comply with the terms set out in the Accord were crushed with the full backing of the ACTU and the ALP². As such, the union bureaucracy actively collaborated with the state to demobilise the movement it supposedly led.

Whilst the bureaucracy enjoyed an exceptionally close relationship with the government, union membership collapsed. At the same time, the ACTU's program of union amalgamation created large unions with hundreds of staff members, further weakening the rank-and-file whilst strengthening the position of the officials.

The Decline of Trade Unions in Australia

The long shadow of the Accord still haunts the Australian union movement today. With the union movement significantly weakened, both Labor and Liberal governments have been able to implement successive waves of anti-union legislation in the decades since 1983.

In 1976, nearly 50% of Australian workers (approximately 2.5 million people) were in a trade union. By 2016, only 14% of Australian workers (1.5 million people) were members of a trade union. In the 1970s,

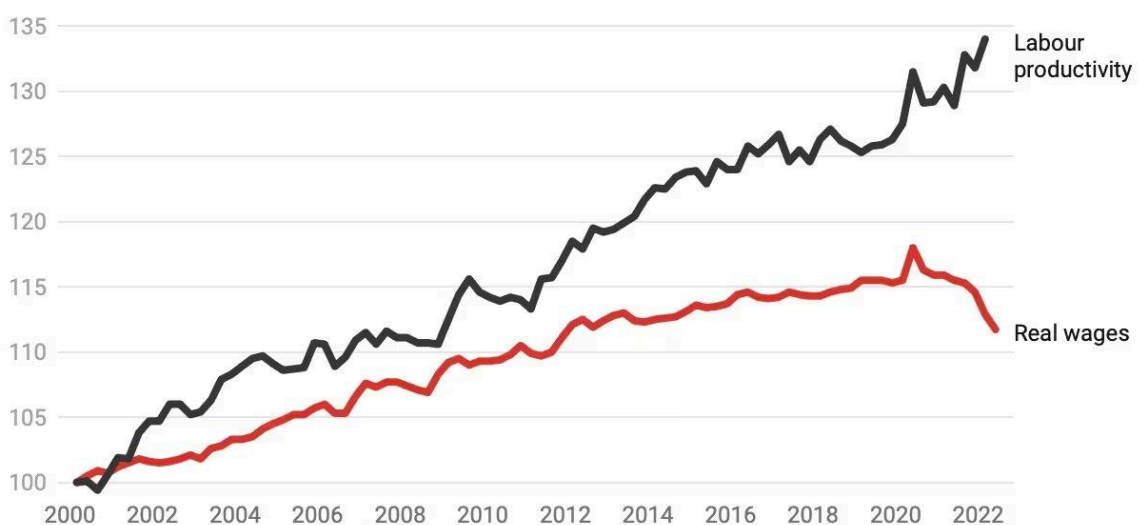
²Examples of this include the deregistration of the Builders Labourers Federation (BLF) in 1986 and the pilots' dispute of 1989.

Australian capitalists “lost” an average 3,146,000 worker days to strike activity each year, the ABS records that in 2019 only 33,500 days were lost to strike activity. Over the same period, workers wages have flatlined and then gradually eroded, whilst corporate profits have continued to soar.

To say that the Australian union movement is in crisis is old news. The union movement in Australia is in the midst of its longest and deepest period of decline, the result of forty years of continuous defeat by capitalists and the state. Despite forty years of defeat, the trade unions remain the largest organised segment within the Australian working class. If the power of the working class is to be rebuilt, the Australian union movement must be rebuilt.

Wages falling behind productivity gains

Growth in labour productivity compared with real wages, 2000 to 2022.



Source: ABS; RBA; University of Sydney.

Discuss

If there is so much power in a union, why aren't all workers unionised? What should be done about it & by whom?

Trade Unions & Anarchism

We believe that anarchists need to organise within the existing trade unions. We need to organise and fight for the daily demands of the working class, whilst winning as many people as possible to our politics. By demonstrating both the beauty and usefulness of liberty, equality and solidarity in the course of our day-to-day struggles, we can convince workers they are also values which are worth building an entire society on.

We endorse a rank-and-file strategy of building workers' power at the base of the unions. Anarchists should be members of their union and must strive to be the best union activists within our workplaces. Where there are workplaces without unions, we have to build the unions. Where there are un-unionised workplaces, we must organise workers into the union. Where there are unionised but pacified workplaces, we must inflame the base to build worker-led campaigns against the bosses.

Through the process of running campaigns from the base of the unions, anarchists will inevitably build up social relationships with their fellow union members. These relationships are the basis of rank-and-file networks of militant workers. Anarchists should embrace these networks and use them to build a rank-and-file movement that is independent of the union bureaucracy and able to fight against it when necessary.

A rank-and-file movement should centre itself on three key demands: strike action, union democracy and working class unity. Strikes are not only the most effective weapon union members have to win the reforms they desire, but they also draw attention to the power of a united working class. As workers withdraw their labour and disrupt production, they begin to realise that they are the ones that make society run, not the bosses. And as workers begin to organise democratically within the union, they also begin to imagine how society as a whole may be run democratically by workers, not the ruling classes. A militant and democratically-run union is therefore one of the best tools for pushing workers towards anarchist ideas.

Additionally, worker-led strikes and democratic structures within the union pull power away from the bureaucracy and put it back in the hands of the rank-and-file. Union officials can only defend their

position as negotiators to the bosses if they are able to call strikes on and off at their will. If instead workers organise to strike on their own, the position of the officials is seriously undermined, as they can no longer act as the sole mediators between the workers and the bosses.

Democratic structures also chip away at the power of the bureaucracy by forcing the officials to be accountable to the rank-and-file, strengthening the power of the latter.

Discuss

Should rank-and-file networks attempt to work with the officials or should they stand in constant opposition to them?

The State and the ALP will oppose all attempts to fully democratise the unions and reignite militant strike action. The State relies on its repressive laws and the trade union bureaucracy to keep militant industrial action low, and thus profits for capitalists high. It will not hesitate to smash unions who begin to step out of line, as it has done several times throughout Australian history.

The ALP, as the party of the trade union bureaucracy, would have no purpose if trade union officials became accountable to their base and began to promote strike action over cosying up with Labor. Thus, strong union democracy and militant strike action in any Australian union, would pose an existential threat to the ALP.

Finally, the unions need to build an iron solidarity to win in the struggles against employers and the State. This requires a resolute stance against all attempts to divide the working class with sexism, racism, transphobia or any other type of oppression. All forms of oppression are attacks on our solidarity and thus attacks on the whole working class. The only effective way of combatting this is to stand on the principle of “an injury to one is an injury to all”.

Discuss

What are some practical steps that we can take towards building rank-and-file movements within the unions?

The Potential for Trade Unions

Workplace struggle is difficult. You can't choose the people to struggle alongside, because they are put there by workplace structures and the bosses.

In addition, the Labor Party has virtually monolithic control of the union bureaucracy and quickly moves to quash any struggle outside of their control. As a result, activists in Australia who consider themselves anarchists have often (usually subconsciously) put the workplace in the “too hard” basket and turned to other arenas of struggle, adapting their political theory to suit.

We thoroughly reject this approach. In fact, we place the gruelling work of building the trade unions at the very centre of our strategy. Why?

Because capitalism's achilles' heel is in the workplace. Ultimately, the ruling class draws its power from control over property and the workplace. So it is in the workplace that the power of capital can be uprooted. The trade unions are one of the best tools the working class has for pursuing this goal. Organised workers can directly put a stop to harmful work (e.g. the transfer of weapons or environmentally destructive projects). Organised workers can repurpose their work to support social movements (e.g. producing goods and services for their fellow workers).

And given that the government has every interest to maintain capitalism as a system, an organised working class movement which can disrupt a national economy is also the most effective force for imposing political demands on the State. Time and time again, workers have organised across industries and walked off the job together to demand that repressive legislation be overturned.

Coordinated strikes like this across many different industries and many different trade unions are called **general strikes**. They are the most powerful tool the working class has to advance its interests. Indeed, the general strike is exactly the tool we would need to have a social revolution. The working class seizing control over the means of production, and co-operating in the self-management of production without bosses or politicians, whilst also opposing all forms of oppression, would be the basis of a free, communist society.

With the hope of the general strike in our hearts, we must commit ourselves to building militant and democratic trade unions.

Discuss

How can struggles 'outside the workplace' complement the trade union movement?

